

Fátima 1917

Event, Message, and Ecclesial Reception

A source-audited apparition study

What the Church has judged, on what record, and what that judgment does and does not oblige

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1 The Judgment First

On 13 October 1930, thirteen years to the day after the last of the reported apparitions, José Alves Correia da Silva, Bishop of Leiria, closed the diocesan inquiry he had opened in 1922 with a pastoral letter on the cult of Our Lady of Fátima. Its operative clauses are short, and everything in this study hangs on reading them exactly.

Operative text — Carta Pastoral of the Bishop of Leiria, 13 October 1930, closing clauses (Portuguese original as printed in the Sanctuary of Fátima’s critical documentary selection)

Havemos por bem

1º declarar como dignas de crédito as visões das crianças na Cova da Iria, freguesia de Fátima, desta Diocese, nos dias 13 de maio a outubro de 1917;

2º permitir oficialmente o culto de Nossa Senhora de Fátima.¹

In editorial rendering: “We deem it well: 1º to declare as worthy of belief the visions of the children at the Cova da Iria, parish of Fátima, of this Diocese, on the 13th of May through October 1917; 2º to permit officially the cult of Our Lady of Fátima.” That is the whole positive judgment: a declaration that the 1917 visions of the three children are *worthy of belief*, and an official permission of cult. The act is diocesan, made by the local ordinary under the pre-1978 discipline in which such judgments belonged to him; it is not a papal definition, not an exercise of infallibility, and not a certification of any text written afterwards. What the Holy See later added—above all the publication and theological interpretation of the “secret” in 2000—was built deliberately on the same restrained foundation, and the Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith stated the limit in words this study treats as controlling: ecclesiastical approval of a private revelation means “the message contains nothing contrary to faith or morals; it is lawful to make it public; and the faithful are authorized to accept it with prudence.”²

Governing thesis

This is an ecclesial-judgment-first study, not a devotional narrative. It reconstructs the Fátima events from the contemporaneous 1917 records; it identifies each competent ecclesiastical act in its exact wording, date, and object; it traces the textual history of the message—above all the late composition of Lucia’s memoirs (1935–1941) and of the three-part secret (written 1941 and 1944, published 1942-era and 2000); and it states what the judgments oblige. Public Revelation is complete in Christ; no Fátima text can add to it, and even an approved private revelation asks only a prudent human assent (*fides humana*), never the divine and Catholic faith owed to Revelation. The 1930 declaration judged the children’s 1917 visions worthy of belief; it did not certify the verbal inerrancy of any reported sentence, the mechanism of the solar phenomenon, or the later texts. Where the record disagrees with itself—as it does about the Lady’s reported October statement on the war—the disagreement is preserved, because a true judgment does not need a corrected record.

The study runs in the order the evidence demands: the 1917 events as their nearest witnesses recorded them (§2); the diocesan process and the 1930 act (§3); the memoirs and the secret’s textual history (§4); the Holy See’s 2000 publication and interpretation (§5); the consecration-of-Russia question through 2022 (§6); reception, canonizations, and the current standing of the judgments under the 2024 norms (§7); and the doctrinal boundary—what approval does and does not oblige (§8). Work-wide bounds, taxonomy, and qualifications are gathered in the terminal appendix; witnesses and rights are in the References.

2 The Events of 1917 in Their Nearest Witnesses

2.1 The seers and the sources

The three children were Lucia de Jesus dos Santos (born in Aljustrel, parish of Fátima, 28 March 1907, registered as 22 March), and her first cousins Francisco Marto (born 1908) and Jacinta Marto (born 1910), children of shepherd families of Aljustrel.³ In 1917 they reported six apparitions of a Lady at the Cova da Iria, about 2.5 km from Fátima, on 13 May, 13 June, 13 July, 19 August (after their detention prevented the expected 13 August encounter), 13 September, and 13 October.

The evidentiary strata must be kept distinct, because they were written at very different distances from the events. Nearest are the contemporaneous records of 1917: the parish priest of Fátima, Manuel Marques Ferreira, began interrogating the children within about two weeks of the first apparition and after each subsequent one; the Lisbon press reported from July onward; and Canon Manuel Nunes Formigão interrogated the children repeatedly from September. These records were critically edited by the Sanctuary of Fátima in the fifteen-volume *Documentação Crítica de Fátima* (1992–2013); this study uses the Sanctuary’s one-volume critical selection of the 1917–1930 documents, which it distributes freely (References). Farthest are Lucia’s memoirs of 1935–1941 and later writings, treated in §4. The contemporaneous records are the strongest evidence for what was publicly said, asked, and observed in 1917; they do not by themselves prove a supernatural origin, and nothing below asserts one.

2.2 May to September in the 1917 record

The parish priest’s first interrogation of Lucia (about 27 May 1917) already fixes the essential shape of the reported first encounter: a Lady seen above a holm oak, a request to return, a promise of heaven.⁴ After the July apparition he interrogated Lucia and Jacinta on 14 July: the Lady asked that they return each 13th and that people “pray the terço [five-decade Rosary] to Our Lady of the Rosary, that she may abate the war, for only she can help it”; asked by Lucia for a miracle so that all would believe, the Lady answered, in the record’s words, “*Daqui a três meses farei então com que todos acreditem*”—within three months I shall make all believe.⁵ The same summer records attest that the children claimed a *secret* they would not reveal: the questioning after 13 August turns on it, and Formigão’s autumn interrogations press all three children about it without obtaining its content.⁶

On 13 August the children never reached the Cova: the administrator of the county of Vila Nova de Ourém, Artur de Oliveira Santos, took them by carriage to Ourém, held them, interrogated them under threats, and released them on the 15th; a crowd at the Cova that day reported unusual atmospheric effects but no vision. The children reported a compensating apparition at Valinhos, near Aljustrel, on 19 August—a date fixed in Lucia’s later Fourth Memoir; the apparition itself is attested in the parish priest’s interrogation of 27 August 1917.⁷ September 13 followed the established pattern before a growing crowd, with the Lady—in the reports—promising that in October “Our Lord, Our Lady of Sorrows and Our Lady of Carmel, and Saint Joseph with the Child Jesus” would come, and that a miracle would be worked.

2.3 13 October and the solar phenomenon

The promised sign drew an enormous crowd to a bare upland in heavy rain. The most quoted description was written by a witness with no stake in the Church’s favor: Avelino de Almeida (1873–1932), special correspondent—*enviado especial*—of *O Século*, the Lisbon daily the Sanctuary’s critical edition identifies as the “daily of the Portuguese Republican Party,” organ of the political world then closing churches and jailing priests; Almeida’s own pre-report of 13 October had treated the affair with open irony. His signed report, published 15 October under the title “Como o sol bailou ao meio dia em Fátima” (How the sun danced at midday at Fátima), estimates the crowd—citing “dispassionate calculations of cultured persons wholly foreign to mystical influences”—at thirty to forty thousand, and describes the moment this way: the rain stopped, the sun appeared “like a disc of dull silver” that could be looked at without strain, and then, “before the astonished eyes of that people. . . the sun trembled, the sun made brusque movements, never seen, outside all cosmic laws—the sun ‘danced,’ in the typical expression of the peasants.”⁸ He closed by handing the question on, not by settling it: “It remains for the competent to pronounce on the macabre dance of the sun which today, at Fátima, made hosannas burst from the breasts of the faithful and naturally impressed—so trustworthy persons assured me—freethinkers and other people without religious concerns.” Two weeks later, in the same paper’s weekly *Ilustração Portuguesa* (29 October), answering a friend who had lost his faith and wanted “an unsuspect testimony,” Almeida held his ground: “Miracle, as the people shouted; natural phenomenon, as the learned say? I do not now care to know, but only to tell you what I saw. . . The rest is for Science and the Church.”⁹

The honest boundaries of this dossier are as important as its strength. The phenomenon was reported by believers and unbelievers, near the Cova and at some distance; descriptions vary (rotation, color changes, an apparent fall toward the earth); some present reported seeing nothing unusual; no astronomical observatory recorded any solar anomaly, so whatever happened was local to the observers. The 1930 pastoral letter itself argued the phenomenon was witnessed by tens of thousands “of all categories and social classes” and was “not natural,” but the operative clause it issued judges the children’s *visions* worthy of belief; the Church has never defined a physical mechanism,

and this study does not certify one, adjudicate every witness, or resolve the natural, psychological, and miraculous hypotheses that have been proposed.¹⁰

What the children themselves reported seeing on 13 October—the Lady as Our Lady of the Rosary asking for a chapel and for the daily Rosary, then tableaux beside the sun of Saint Joseph with the Child, Our Lord, Our Lady of Sorrows, and Our Lady of Carmel—is recorded in the parish priest’s interrogation of 16 October and, at greater length, in the memoirs.¹¹

2.4 A preserved discrepancy: the October war statement

The same 16 October interrogation records Lucia reporting the Lady’s words as: “*a guerra acaba ainda hoje; esperem cá pelos seus militares, muito breve*”—the war ends this very day; expect your soldiers here very soon. The war did not end that day; it ended in November 1918. Formigão pressed exactly this point on 19 October: “But look, the war is still going on! . . . How is this explained, if Our Lady said the war ended that day?” Lucia: “I do not know. I only know that I heard her say that the war would end on the 13th. I do not know anything else.” And, pressed with her own earlier statement that the end would come “soon after”: “I no longer remember well how she said it. She may have said that; I do not know. Perhaps I did not understand the Lady well.”¹²

The discrepancy is published here because it is consequential and because both honest options remain open within the Church’s own frame: either the ten-year-old, questioned in a chaos of light and crowd, misreported or misremembered a sentence, or the sentence was conditioned or temporally compressed in ways the hearer could not carry. The 2000 theological commentary supplies the controlling category: interior visions are received “in the modes of representation and consciousness available” to the seer, and are “never simple ‘photographs’ of the other world” (§5). A worthy-of-belief judgment is not a warranty of verbal inerrancy, and the 1930 act nowhere claims one. What the discrepancy does not license is silently correcting the 1917 record to match the memoirs, or treating the whole dossier as thereby discredited: the bishop judged in 1930 with these same documents before his commission.

3 The Diocesan Process and the 1930 Judgment

3.1 Jurisdiction and process, 1918–1930

The apparition site lay in the ancient diocese of Leiria, suppressed in the nineteenth century and restored by Benedict XV in 1918; its first new bishop, José Alves Correia da Silva, took possession in 1920. Competence over the events therefore belonged to him as diocesan ordinary under the discipline then in force, in which the judgment of reported apparitions lay with the local bishop—the regime later codified by the Holy Office’s 1978 norms and replaced in 2024 (§7).¹³

By a *provisão* of 3 May 1922 the bishop opened the canonical process: the document expressly declines to pronounce “on the origin and nature of the extraordinary phenomena,” names a commission of diocesan clergy to study the alleged facts and organize the process, orders the text read in every church of the diocese, and counsels the faithful to “await the judgment of Holy Church.”¹⁴ The process gathered the 1917 interrogations and testimony; its formal core was the sworn interrogation of Lucia—by then the only surviving seer—conducted 8 July 1924 at the Asilo de Vilar in Porto by three seminary professors with the permission of the Bishop of Porto, the record being joined to the Leiria process. The commission reported to the bishop on 13 April 1930.¹⁵

3.2 The act of 13 October 1930

The bishop’s *Carta Pastoral sobre o culto de Nossa Senhora de Fátima*, dated at Leiria 13 October 1930 and read at the Cova da Iria before a great pilgrimage, reviews the events, the hostile and favorable testimony, the solar phenomenon, the discipline of the intervening years (including his own long reserve), and the fruits observed at the site; then, “having heard the Reverend Consultors of this our Diocese,” it issues the two operative clauses quoted at the head of this study: the visions of the children at the Cova da Iria on the 13ths of May through October 1917 are declared *worthy of belief* (*dignas de crédito*), and the cult of Our Lady of Fátima is officially permitted.¹⁶

Read strictly, the act does four things and no more. (1) Its *object* is “the visions of the children” at the Cova da Iria, May through October 1917: not the 1916 angel apparitions, not the reported 1915 figures, not Lucia’s later experiences at Pontevedra (1925–1926) or Tuy (1929), not any text of the then-unwritten memoirs, and not the still-secret parts of the message. (2) Its *standard* is credibility—“worthy of belief”—the classical formula by which an ordinary declares that the faithful may prudently believe a private revelation, not that they must, and not that its supernatural origin is a certainty of faith. (3) It *permits* public cult, which the diocese had until then only tolerated; this is the juridical foundation of the Sanctuary. (4) It binds no conscience: under the doctrine received then and since, assent to an approved apparition remains *fides humana*, prudent human credence (§8). The act’s own argumentative sections—on the solar phenomenon, on cures, on the movement of pilgrims—are the bishop’s motivation, not further operative determinations.

3.3 Witness and accessibility ceilings

Precision about the witness matters. This study quotes the 1930 operative clauses from the Sanctuary of Fátima’s own critical edition: *Documentação Crítica de Fátima: Seleção de documentos (1917–1930)* (Fátima: Santuário de Fátima, 2013; ISBN 978-972-8213-91-6), Doc. 133, a volume the Sanctuary distributes without charge as a PDF from its documentation pages. That edition prints the full Portuguese text with the editors’ apparatus and identifies its earlier publication in the series (DCF II, Doc. 11). The ceilings: the original printed pastoral letter (União Gráfica, Lisbon, 1930) and the diocesan archive original were not consulted; no official English translation of the act has been identified, so all English here is editorial; and the fifteen-volume critical series itself was used only through the Sanctuary’s one-volume selection. Within those bounds the wording rests on the Sanctuary’s critical transcription, which is the best witness generally accessible.¹⁷

4 The Memoirs and the Textual History of the Secret

4.1 Late composition, and why it matters

Nearly everything the devout world knows as “the message of Fátima” beyond the bare 1917 record comes from documents Lucia wrote between eighteen and twenty-seven years after the events, in obedience to her bishop: the First Memoir (finished 25 December 1935), centered on Jacinta; the Second (21 November 1937), which first narrates the 1916 angel apparitions at length and her own interior history; the Third (31 August 1941), which first reveals the first two parts of the secret; and the Fourth (8 December 1941), a comprehensive account with annotations—including her note that, except the part of the secret she was not then permitted to reveal, “I shall say everything. I shall not knowingly omit anything, though I suppose I may forget just a few small details of minor importance.”¹⁸

The historiographical care this demands is not suspicion but proportion. The memoirs are retrospective spiritual autobiography, written after the Russian revolutions of 1917, after the rise of Soviet communism and its persecutions, after the great aurora of 25 January 1938, and—for the Third and Fourth—into the Second World War; their author herself distinguishes what she may reveal from what she may not, and warns of forgetfulness in details. The 1917 documents verify that a secret existed and that a miracle was promised three months ahead; they do not contain the 1941 wording. Sound method therefore reads each memoir as a witness to what Lucia, in 1935–1941, believed and remembered herself to have experienced—a witness the Church took seriously enough to build on, but not a stenographic deposit of 1917. The Church’s own 2000 commentary adopted precisely this frame for the visions themselves (§5).

4.2 The three parts: composition, custody, publication

Parts one and two. As written in the Third Memoir (31 August 1941) and annotated in the Fourth, the first part is the vision of hell shown to the children on 13 July 1917; the second is the announcement of devotion to the Immaculate Heart of Mary as the means God wills “to save poor sinners,” with the conditional prophecy the 2000 edition prints in full: the war will end, but if offenses do not cease a worse one will break out under Pius XI; a night illumined by an unknown light will be the sign; to prevent this “I shall come to ask for the consecration of Russia to my Immaculate Heart, and the Communion of reparation on the First Saturdays”; if heeded, “Russia will be converted, and there will be peace; if not, she will spread her errors throughout the world. . . .”; “In the end, my

Immaculate Heart will triumph. The Holy Father will consecrate Russia to me, and she shall be converted, and a period of peace will be granted to the world.”¹⁹ These two parts entered public circulation in the early 1940s—the standard dating is 1942, in anniversary publications authorized in Portugal—so that by the 1950s they were common property of theological discussion; the 2000 edition simply describes them as “already... published and therefore known.” The 1942 first imprints were not re-verified here (Appendix A).²⁰

Part three. Lucia wrote the third part at Tuy on 3 January 1944, “by order of His Excellency the Bishop of Leiria and the Most Holy Mother...,” after months of anguished hesitation; there is one manuscript, which the 2000 edition reproduces photostatically. The sealed envelope stayed with the Bishop of Leiria until, “to ensure better protection,” it was placed in the Secret Archives of the Holy Office on 4 April 1957. John XXIII received the envelope on 17 August 1959, said—as the archives record—“We shall wait. I shall pray. I shall let you know what I decide,” and decided to return it unpublished; Paul VI read the text on 27 March 1965 and likewise returned it; John Paul II asked for it after the attempt on his life of 13 May 1981.²¹

The 1960 date. On the outer envelope Lucia had written that it could be opened only after 1960, by the Patriarch of Lisbon or the Bishop of Leiria. Decades of speculation attached to that date. Asked directly in the recorded conversation of 27 April 2000—“Why only after 1960? Was it Our Lady who fixed that date?”—Sister Lucia answered: “It was not Our Lady. I fixed the date because I had the intuition that before 1960 it would not be understood, but that only later would it be understood. Now it can be better understood. I wrote down what I saw; however it was not for me to interpret it, but for the Pope.”²²

Publication, 26 June 2000. At the end of the beatification Mass at Fátima on 13 May 2000, Cardinal Angelo Sodano, Secretary of State, announced by the Pope’s direction that the third part would be published after preparation of a commentary. The Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith published *The Message of Fatima* on 26 June 2000: a complete documentary dossier containing Bertone’s introduction; the photostat and translation of the first two parts (Third Memoir text with Fourth Memoir annotations); the photostat and translation of the third part; John Paul II’s letter of 19 April 2000 to Sister Lucia; the account of the 27 April 2000 conversation; Sodano’s 13 May announcement; and Cardinal Joseph Ratzinger’s theological commentary. The vision of the third part, in the Holy See’s translation: an Angel with a flaming sword crying “Penance, Penance, Penance!”; “a Bishop dressed in White” (“we had the impression that it was the Holy Father”) climbing with others toward a great rough-hewn cross past a city half in ruins, praying for the corpses he met; killed at the summit “by a group of soldiers who fired bullets and arrows at him,” with bishops, priests, religious, and laity dying after him; and two Angels beneath the cross gathering the martyrs’ blood and sprinkling it on the souls making their way to God.²³

The completeness of that publication was later challenged in print through claims attributed to a German professor; the Holy See’s 2016 response, and Benedict XVI’s personal denial, are treated with the reception history in §7. Textually, the position of record is the 2000 edition’s: one manuscript, reproduced in facsimile, published entire.

5 The Holy See’s Interpretation (2000)

5.1 The papal application and Sodano’s announcement

John Paul II read his own survival of 13 May 1981—the anniversary of the first apparition—within the third part’s vision of the “Bishop dressed in White.” His formula, quoted in the 2000 dossier from his 1994 meditation to the Italian bishops: “it was a mother’s hand that guided the bullet’s path and in his throes the Pope halted at the threshold of death.” Sodano’s 13 May 2000 announcement made the ecclesial application public: the text is “a prophetic vision similar to those found in Sacred Scripture, which do not describe photographically the details of future events, but synthesize and compress against a single background facts which extend through time in an unspecified succession and duration”; it “must be interpreted in a symbolic key”; the vision “concerns above all the war waged by atheistic systems against the Church and Christians,” an “interminable Way of the Cross led by the Popes of the twentieth century,” in which the Pope of the vision, “he too falls to the ground, apparently dead, under a hail of gunfire”—while “the events to which the third part of the ‘secret’ of Fatima refers now seem part of the past.”²⁴ Sister Lucia, shown the interpretation before the announcement, “said that this interpretation corresponded to what she had experienced”—while insisting, as she had in 1982, that “she had received the vision but not its interpretation,” which “belonged not to the visionary but to the Church.”²⁵

5.2 Ratzinger's theological commentary

Cardinal Ratzinger's commentary is the doctrinal center of the 2000 publication, and its exact wording carries the weight. On the status of such phenomena: public Revelation "came to an end with the fulfilment of the mystery of Christ"; private revelations, in the Catechism's words, do not "complete Christ's definitive Revelation, but... help live more fully by it in a certain period of history"; and the authority of the two "differ[s] not only in degree but also in essence." He retrieves Prospero Lambertini's classical rule—"An assent of Catholic faith is not due to revelations approved in this way; it is not even possible. These revelations seek rather an assent of human faith in keeping with the requirements of prudence, which puts them before us as probable and credible to piety"—and Dhanis's three elements of approval quoted in §1, adding: "It is a help which is offered, but which one is not obliged to use."²⁶

On the anthropology of the visions: the Fátima experiences belong to *interior* perception (*visio imaginativa*), not exterior sense-perception nor pure intellectual vision. "Interior vision does not mean fantasy... the soul is touched by something real, even if beyond the senses," yet "the subject, the visionary, is still more powerfully involved. He sees insofar as he is able, in the modes of representation and consciousness available to him... Such visions therefore are never simple 'photographs' of the other world, but are influenced by the potentialities and limitations of the perceiving subject"—so that "the images are, in a manner of speaking, a synthesis of the impulse coming from on high and the capacity to receive this impulse in the visionaries." Not every element need carry "a specific historical sense"; "it is the vision as a whole that matters."²⁷

On the content: the key of the first two parts is "to save souls"—the vision of hell is ordered to rescue, and devotion to the Immaculate Heart means, through Mt 5:8, "a heart which, with God's grace, has come to perfect interior unity and therefore 'sees God'," making *fiat* "the defining centre of one's whole life." The key word of the third part is "the threefold cry: 'Penance, Penance, Penance!'" Against fatalist readings he is categorical: "the future is not in fact unchangeably set," "the purpose of the vision is not to show a film of an irrevocably fixed future. Its meaning is exactly the opposite: it is meant to mobilize the forces of change in the right direction"; "we must totally discount fatalistic explanations of the 'secret', such as, for example, the claim that the would-be assassin of 13 May 1981 was merely an instrument of the divine plan guided by Providence"; and, of the deflected bullet, "there is no immutable destiny," for "faith and prayer are forces which can influence history... in the end prayer is more powerful than bullets and faith more powerful than armies." His reading of the whole concedes disappointment to the curious—"no great mystery is revealed; nor is the future unveiled"—and ends on the promise: "'my Immaculate Heart will triumph'... The Heart open to God, purified by contemplation of God, is stronger than guns and weapons of every kind," because Mary's *fiat* brought into the world the One who said, "In the world you will have tribulation, but take heart; I have overcome the world."²⁸

Two boundary notes keep this section honest. First, the commentary is authoritative interpretation by the Prefect of the doctrinal congregation, published by that congregation with papal approval of the publication; it is not a definition, and it presents itself as "an attempt." Second, the papal application of the vision to 13 May 1981 is a privileged reading confirmed by the surviving seer, not a demonstrated one-to-one decoding; the commentary's own principles (symbol, compression, the whole over the detail) forbid pressing any single image—city, arrows, the "etc." of the Fourth Memoir—into a private key for future events.

6 The Consecration-of-Russia Question

6.1 The reported requests (1917, 1925, 1929)

Within the secret's second part as written in 1941, the Lady of 1917 says: "I shall come to ask for the consecration of Russia to my Immaculate Heart, and the Communion of reparation on the First Saturdays." Lucia reported the fulfillments of that announcement in her later religious life: at Pontevedra on 10 December 1925, an apparition of Our Lady and the Child Jesus requesting the Five First Saturdays devotion of reparation; at Tuy on 13 June 1929, an apparition of Our Lady with a vision of the Most Holy Trinity, in which—as the Dicastery for the Causes of Saints' 2023 decree summarizes—"the Consecration of Russia to the Immaculate Heart of Mary was asked of her," to be made by the Pope in union with the bishops of the world.²⁹

6.2 The papal acts (1942–1984) and the 1989 letter

The sequence of papal acts, each with its own object, is best given as the record states it. Pius XII, closing the Portuguese jubilee of the apparitions’ twenty-fifth anniversary by radio message of 31 October 1942, consecrated the Church and the human race to the Immaculate Heart of Mary, with a veiled paragraph for “the peoples separated by error or discord,” notably those where “there was no house where not held in honor” was Mary’s venerable icon; on 7 July 1952, in the apostolic letter *Sacro vergente anno* addressed to the peoples of Russia, he consecrated “in a most special way, all the peoples of Russia to the same Immaculate Heart.”³⁰

John Paul II composed an Act of Entrustment celebrated at Saint Mary Major on 7 June 1981 (his recorded address was broadcast, since he was convalescing), repeated it at Fátima on 13 May 1982, and on 25 March 1984, in Saint Peter’s Square, “in spiritual union with the Bishops of the world, who had been ‘convoked’ beforehand,” entrusted and consecrated to the Immaculate Heart “this human world of ours. . . In a special way we entrust and consecrate to you those individuals and nations which particularly need to be thus entrusted and consecrated.” Russia is not named in the 1984 text. The 2000 dossier prints both prayers and then settles the question the movements of the 1980s had kept alive, on the testimony of the seer herself: “Sister Lucia personally confirmed that this solemn and universal act of consecration corresponded to what Our Lady wished (. . . ‘Yes it has been done just as Our Lady asked, on 25 March 1984’: Letter of 8 November 1989). Hence any further discussion or request is without basis.”³¹

The honest historical note is that Lucia’s recorded expectations earlier in the 1980s were more exacting (explicit naming of Russia; formal participation of every bishop), and public controversy has never entirely ceased. The position of record in the Church is the one just quoted: the 1989 letter and the 2000 publication close the question, and no competent authority has reopened it. This study reports the closure as the controlling status and the prior discussion as history, without adjudicating archival claims it has not seen.

6.3 The 2022 act of Francis

On 25 March 2022, a month into the war in Ukraine and “in response to numerous requests by the People of God,” Pope Francis—asking by letter of 21 March that the bishops of the whole world join him—carried out during a penitential celebration in Saint Peter’s Basilica an “Act of Consecration to the Immaculate Heart of Mary,” this time naming nations explicitly: “Mother of God and our Mother, to your Immaculate Heart we solemnly entrust and consecrate ourselves, the Church and all humanity, especially Russia and Ukraine.” The same act was performed that day at the Sanctuary of Fátima by the Apostolic Almoner, Cardinal Konrad Krajewski, as the Pope’s envoy.³²

6.4 Boundary

No consecration is a dogma, a divination, or a political instrument. The acts of 1942, 1952, 1984, and 2022 are solemn exercises of papal piety and pastoral government, each defined by its own text; none declares a historical “conversion of Russia” accomplished, none fixes a calendar for the promised “period of peace,” and none licenses treating any nation as the unique embodiment of evil. The 2000 commentary’s rule governs here too: the prophecy is conditional, addressed to freedom—“it is people themselves who are preparing their own punishment,” as Lucia wrote in 1982—and its center is conversion, not geopolitics.³³

7 Reception, Canonizations, and Current Standing

7.1 Papal and ecclesial reception

Reception followed the 1930 judgment in the forms proper to each act, none of which upgrades the judgment itself: Pius XII’s radio messages and the 1942 and 1952 consecrations (§6); Paul VI’s pilgrimage of 13 May 1967 for the fiftieth anniversary, with the apostolic exhortation *Signum magnum* signed that day; John Paul II’s pilgrimages of 1982, 1991, and 2000; Benedict XVI’s of 2010; Francis’s of 2017 and 2023. Benedict XVI’s homily at Fátima on 13 May 2010 gave the reception its lasting formula of continuing relevance: “We would be mistaken to think that Fatima’s prophetic mission is complete”—prophetic here in exactly the sense his own 2000 commentary had defined, a summons to conversion, not a further calendar.³⁴

7.2 The seers’ causes and the centenary canonizations

Francisco Marto died 4 April 1919, Jacinta 20 February 1920, both of the pneumonic influenza epidemic. Their joint cause produced decrees of heroic virtues signed by John Paul II on 13 May 1989—the first recognition of heroic virtue in non-martyr children, a decision of general import for the Church’s understanding of childhood sanctity—and he beatified them at Fátima on 13 May 2000, before the announcement of the third part’s publication. Francis canonized them at Fátima on 13 May 2017, during the Mass of the apparitions’ centenary: the first canonized non-martyr children, and the first saints of the Fátima event itself. His homily held the canonization inside the message’s own center—“We can take as our examples Saint Francisco and Saint Jacinta, whom the Virgin Mary introduced into the immense ocean of God’s light and taught to adore him”—and quoted the Third Memoir’s account of Jacinta’s vision of a suffering pope.³⁵ Sister Lucia died in the Carmel of Coimbra on 13 February 2005; Benedict XVI dispensed from the customary five-year wait so that her cause could open in Coimbra in 2008, and Pope Francis approved the decree of her heroic virtues on 22 June 2023, giving her the title Venerable; her beatification awaits an approved miracle.³⁶

7.3 The 2016 communiqué on the “incomplete publication” claims

In 2016 several outlets circulated statements attributed to the German professor Ingo Dollinger, according to which Cardinal Ratzinger had privately confided, after June 2000, that the publication of the third secret was incomplete. The Holy See Press Office answered on 21 May 2016 with a communiqué whose operative sentences deserve exact quotation: “Pope emeritus Benedict XVI declares ‘never to have spoken with Professor Dollinger about Fatima’, clearly affirming that the remarks attributed to Professor Dollinger on the matter ‘are pure inventions, absolutely untrue’, and he confirms decisively that ‘the publication of the Third Secret of Fatima is complete.’”³⁷ With that declaration, every layer of the textual question—manuscript, facsimile, translation, completeness—stands publicly closed by the persons with direct knowledge.

7.4 Standing under the 2024 norms

The Dicastery for the Doctrine of the Faith’s *Norms for Proceeding in the Discernment of Alleged Supernatural Phenomena* (approved 4 May 2024; effective 19 May 2024, Pentecost) replaced the 1978 norms and restructured conclusions into six determinations: *Nihil obstat*; *Prae oculis habeatur*; *Curatur*; *Sub mandato*; *Prohibetur et obstruatur*; and *Declaratio de non supernaturalitate*. As a rule, “neither the Diocesan Bishop, nor the Episcopal Conferences, nor the Dicastery will declare that these phenomena are of supernatural origin, even if a *Nihil obstat* is granted,” though “the Holy Father can authorize a special procedure in this regard.”³⁸ Three consequences for Fátima, stated carefully. First, the norms govern *proceedings*; they do not retroactively reclassify legacy decisions, and the 1930 declaration remains what it always was—a positive diocesan judgment in its own historical formula (“worthy of belief”), which this study does not relabel as a 2024-vocabulary *Nihil obstat*. Second, the norms’ own presentation cites Fátima as the standing example of what approval means, quoting the 2000 explanation that “ecclesiastical approval of a private revelation highlights that the message contains nothing contrary to faith or morals” (26 June 2000). Third, no act of the Dicastery under the new norms concerns Fátima: the DDF’s public documents index contains, for Fátima, only the 2000 *Message of Fatima* dossier (checked 2026-07-25), and no later Holy See intervention superseding the 1930 judgment or the 2000 interpretation was located in the sources searched. Silence is reported as a bounded negative search, not as a guarantee.³⁹

Controlling-status dossier — Fátima, as of 2026-07-25
Event identity: Six reported apparitions of Our Lady to Lucia dos Santos, Francisco Marto, and Jacinta Marto at the Cova da Iria, parish of Fátima, 13 May–13 October 1917 (August encounter at Valinhos, 19 August), with the reported solar phenomenon of 13 October 1917 Jurisdiction: Diocese of Leiria (now Leiria-Fátima), Latin Church, Portugal Competent act: Carta Pastoral of Bishop José Alves Correia da Silva, 13 October 1930, Portuguese; witness: <i>Documentação Crítica de Fátima: Seleção</i> (2013), Doc. 133 Procedural regime: Pre-1978 diocesan-ordinary discernment; process opened 3 May 1922; commission report 13 April 1930 Operative formula: “declarar como dignas de crédito as visões das crianças... nos dias 13 de maio a outubro de 1917” and “permitir oficialmente o culto de Nossa Senhora de Fátima”

Exact object: The children’s 1917 Cova da Iria visions and the public cult; not the 1916 angel cycle, the 1915 reports, the 1921 experience, Pontevedra 1925–1926, Tuy 1929, the memoirs, or the secret’s texts

Later acts: Custody and publication of the third part (CDF, 26 June 2000, with theological commentary); papal consecrations 1942, 1952, 1984, 2022; beatification 2000 and canonization 2017 of Francisco and Jacinta; Lucia declared Venerable 2023; 2016 communiqué affirming complete publication

Current status: Positive legacy diocesan judgment in force; 2000 CDF interpretation controlling for the secret; no DDF act under the 2024 norms; no located superseding or restricting act

What it does not establish: Obligation of faith; verbal inerrancy of reported words (see the October war statement); a defined mechanism for the solar phenomenon; authentication of every later text, promise, or private interpretation

8 What Approval Does and Does Not Oblige

8.1 The *fides humana* boundary

The doctrinal architecture is fixed and simple. Public Revelation is complete in Christ: “In Christ, God has said everything, that is, he has revealed himself completely,” as the 2000 commentary puts it, “and therefore Revelation came to an end with the fulfilment of the mystery of Christ.” Recognized private revelations do not belong to the deposit of faith; in the Catechism’s words, “it is not their role to complete Christ’s definitive Revelation, but to help live more fully by it in a certain period of history” (CCC 67). The assent owed to Revelation is divine and Catholic faith; the assent invited by an approved apparition is, in Lambertini’s rule as retrieved by the 2000 commentary, “an assent of human faith in keeping with the requirements of prudence”—and an assent of Catholic faith to it “is not even possible.” Approval means the message contains nothing against faith or morals, may be published, and may prudently be believed; “it is a help which is offered, but which one is not obliged to use.”⁴⁰

Concretely, for Fátima: a Catholic is free—reasonably, prudently, without disloyalty—to believe that Our Lady appeared at the Cova da Iria, and free not to. What no Catholic is free to do is invert the order of assent: to treat the message as a second deposit of faith, an oracle that settles doctrine, binds consciences, predicts obligatory futures, directs political allegiance, or substitutes for Scripture, liturgy, and the sacraments. The Church’s whole handling of the case—the bishop’s eight years of reserve, the restrained 1930 formula, forty-three years of unpublished custody of the third part, the 2000 commentary’s insistence that prophecy “show[s] the right path to take for the future” rather than satisfying curiosity—is one long enforcement of that order.

8.2 What the positive judgments leave unjudged

Each act reaches its own object, and the gaps are part of the record. The 1930 declaration does not reach the angel apparitions of 1916, the Pontevedra and Tuy experiences, or any text of the memoirs and the secret—these stand on the Holy See’s later practical reception, which published, interpreted, and built devotion upon them without ever issuing a formal supernaturality judgment on them. The canonizations certify the sanctity of Francisco and Jacinta, not the accuracy of every remembered dialogue. The consecrations are acts of papal piety defined by their texts. The 2000 publication closes the textual question of the secret and gives the Church’s interpretation; its own author calls the interpretation “an attempt.” And no act, diocesan or Roman, has ever judged the mechanism of the solar phenomenon, guaranteed the verbal inerrancy of the children’s reported sentences, or authenticated the “devotional accretions, promises, and private interpretations” that circulate under Fátima’s name. Where a claim exceeds its act, the excess is the claimant’s.⁴¹

8.3 The message’s evangelical center

Read under those controls, what the approved Fátima proposes is almost severe in its simplicity: conversion; penance; the daily Rosary (asked, in the 1917 records, at every apparition); reparation, above all Eucharistic, for sin; intercession for sinners—“many souls go to hell, because there are none to sacrifice themselves and to pray for them,” in the memoirs’ account of the Valinhos words; devotion to the Immaculate Heart as schooling in Mary’s *fiat*; and peace in history as a fruit hanging on human freedom before God. Everything in it leads back into the Gospel it cannot supplement—which is, by the Church’s stated criterion, the very mark of its credibility.⁴²

9 Notes

1. Carta Pastoral de D. José Alves Correia da Silva, Bispo de Leiria, sobre o culto de Nossa Senhora de Fátima, 13 October 1930, closing clauses, quoted from *Documentação Crítica de Fátima: Seleção de documentos (1917–1930)* (Fátima: Santuário de Fátima, 2013), Doc. 133 (there recorded as published in DCF II, Doc. 11), at the volume’s printed pages 550–551; read 2026-07-25 in the Sanctuary’s freely downloaded PDF of the volume (References). All web loci cited in these notes were read on 2026-07-25 unless another date is stated. The English renderings of Portuguese sources in this study are editorial working translations, visibly commentary, not received translation witnesses.
2. Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, *The Message of Fatima* (26 June 2000), theological commentary of Cardinal Joseph Ratzinger, summarizing E. Dhanis; English text at https://www.vatican.va/roman_curia/congregations/cfaith/documents/rc_con_cfaith_doc_20000626_message-fatima_en.html. The Dicastery for the Doctrine of the Faith’s 2024 norms cite this same 2000 explanation as the standing account of what approval means (References).
3. Birth and family data: the editorial notes to Doc. 1 of the *Seleção de documentos* (the parish priest’s first interrogation), which record Lucia’s baptismal register date and family; the Sanctuary’s “Chronology of the Three Seers” page, <https://www.fatima.pt/en/pages/chronology-of-the-three-seers>, which explains the 22/28 March discrepancy from Lucia’s Fifth Memoir; and the Dicastery for the Causes of Saints’ decree on Lucia’s heroic virtues, 22 June 2023 (References). The ages printed under the photograph in *O Século* (10, 9, 7) are the newspaper’s.
4. *Seleção*, Doc. 1 (1917-05-c.27), publishing DCF I, Doc. 1. The interrogation records of the parish priest are summaries made by him, not stenographic transcripts.
5. *Seleção*, Doc. 3 (1917-07-14), publishing DCF I, Doc. 3. The promise of a sign three months ahead is therefore attested in writing three months *before* 13 October —the single most important contemporaneous control on the October crowd.
6. Secret attested in 1917: e.g. *Seleção*, Doc. 120’s account of the 13 August detention (the administrator sought “to tear from them the secret”), and Formigão’s September–October interrogations (Docs. 8–12, 18), which ask each child about the secret and record their refusal. The 1917 record proves that a secret was claimed; it does not contain the content later written in 1941 and 1944.
7. Detention: *Seleção*, Doc. 120 (the diocesan commission’s 1930 report, drawing on the sworn 1924 interrogation) and the 1917 press; Valinhos: the Sanctuary’s “Narrative of the Apparitions” page, which prints the Fourth Memoir account and notes that the bracketed portion comes from the parish priest’s interrogation of 27 August 1917 (DCF I, p. 17). The *day* 19 August rests on the memoir stratum; the fact of an August apparition away from the Cova is contemporaneous.
8. *Seleção*, Doc. 13 (1917-10-15), publishing DCF III-1, Doc. 87, at the volume’s printed pages 72–78; the crowd estimate and the quoted sentences are at pp. 75–76 (editorial translation; Portuguese: “o sol tremeu, o sol teve nunca vistos movimentos bruscos fora de todas as leis cósmicas — o sol ‘bailou’, segundo a típica expressão dos camponeses”). Almeida died in 1932; the underlying 1917 newspaper text is in the public domain.
9. *Seleção*, Doc. 21 (1917-10-29), publishing DCF III-1, Doc. 228, printed pages 114–116 (editorial translation).
10. The pastoral letter’s argumentation about the solar phenomenon precedes its operative clauses (*Seleção*, Doc. 133). The negative astronomical control (no registered global anomaly) is common ground in the literature and follows from the event’s local visibility; it is stated here as a bound, not as a refutation.
11. *Seleção*, Doc. 14 (1917-10-16), publishing DCF I, Doc. 6; Fourth Memoir account as printed by the Sanctuary’s “Narrative of the Apparitions” page.
12. Interrogation of 16 October: *Seleção*, Doc. 14; Formigão’s interrogation (redacted after 19 October): Doc. 18, publishing DCF I, Doc. 16, questions 1–6 (editorial translation). The later Fourth Memoir stratum gives the October words as “the war is going to end”; the 1941 text and the 1917 records are not verbally identical.
13. Diocesan restoration and the bishop’s role: the introductory study and chronology of the *Seleção de documentos*; the bishop met Lucia about 1920–1921 (Sanctuary seer chronology). On the procedural regimes: DDF, *Norms for Proceeding in the Discernment of Alleged Supernatural Phenomena* (2024), presentation, and its replacement of the norms of 25 February 1978 (art. 27).
14. *Seleção*, Doc. 68 (1922-05-03), publishing DCF II, Doc. 1; the commission’s character as preparatory is stated in the commission’s own 1930 report (Doc. 120): the provision was issued “not to pronounce on the origin and nature of the extraordinary phenomena, but to prepare the elements on which ecclesiastical authority must base itself in order to render its verdict with full knowledge of the cause” (editorial translation).
15. *Seleção*, Doc. 120 (1930-04-13), the commission’s report, which recounts the 6 July 1924 request to the Bishop of Porto, the 8 July 1924 sworn interrogation of the seventeen-year-old Lucia, and the 13 August 1917 detention episode. Francisco had died 4 April 1919 and Jacinta 20 February 1920 (Sanctuary seer chronology; canonization records, §7).

16. *Seleção*, Doc. 133 (1930-10-13), publishing DCF II, Doc. 11 (also DCF V-6, Doc. 1813), printed pages 539–551. The solemn announcement at the Cova da Iria on the same day, with the bishop’s blessing of the multitude, is documented in the press account printed as Doc. 134 of the same volume.
17. Edition identity and free distribution: title, ISBN, and copyright leaf of the *Seleção* PDF; download route in the References. The 1930 act is not printed in *Acta Apostolicae Sedis*, which records Holy See acts; a diocesan pastoral letter would not be expected there, and no AAS locus is claimed.
18. Memoir dates: the Sanctuary’s seer chronology (25 December 1935; 21 November 1937; 31 August 1941; 8 December 1941), corroborated for the Third and Fourth by the CDF’s *Message of Fatima* (2000), which prints the secret’s first two parts from the Third Memoir and quotes the Fourth Memoir’s undertaking in its note 6. The Dicastery for the Causes of Saints’ 2023 decree likewise dates the memoirs 1935–1941, “by order of the Bishop of Leiria.” Fifth and Sixth Memoirs (1989, 1993) concern her parents and are not used here.
19. CDF, *The Message of Fatima* (2000), “First and second part of the ‘secret’ according to the version presented by Sister Lucia in the Third Memoir of 31 August 1941 for the Bishop of Leiria-Fatima,” quoted from the Holy See’s English translation. The Fourth Memoir’s added sentence—“In Portugal, the dogma of the faith will always be preserved etc. [...]”—is printed by the 2000 edition as its note 7; the Holy See published it as an annotation and offered no interpretation of the “etc.”
20. CDF, *Message of Fatima*, Bertone introduction; the theological commentary cites the state of discussion in E. Dhanis, “Sguardo su Fatima e bilancio di una discussione,” *La Civiltà Cattolica* 104 (1953) II, 392–406. Pius XII’s Fátima-jubilee radio message of 31 October 1942 (§6) belongs to the same anniversary moment.
21. All custody facts: CDF, *Message of Fatima*, Bertone introduction, with its notes 1–2 (John XXIII’s diary for 17 August 1959; the July–August 1981 movements of the two envelopes). The envelope’s text and the translation policy—“the original text... has been respected, even as regards the imprecise punctuation”—are the edition’s.
22. CDF, *Message of Fatima*, “Conversation with Sister Maria Lucia of Jesus and the Immaculate Heart,” 27 April 2000, Carmel of Coimbra, conducted by Archbishop Tarcisio Bertone with Bishop Serafim de Sousa Ferreira e Silva of Leiria-Fátima at John Paul II’s written commission of 19 April 2000 (both documents in the 2000 edition).
23. CDF, *Message of Fatima*, third part of the “secret,” translation of the manuscript of 3 January 1944 (Tuy); Sodano announcement of 13 May 2000, *ibid.* Lucia confirmed the manuscript and her handwriting in the 27 April 2000 conversation.
24. CDF, *Message of Fatima*: Sodano announcement, 13 May 2000 (English translation of the Portuguese delivered at Fátima); John Paul II, meditation from the Policlinico Gemelli to the Italian bishops, 13 May 1994, as quoted there and in the 27 April 2000 conversation record. The bullet from the 1981 attempt was set, by the Bishop of Leiria-Fátima’s decision, in the crown of the statue of Our Lady of Fátima (Sodano announcement).
25. CDF, *Message of Fatima*, theological commentary (on the interpretation being put to Lucia); her letter of 12 May 1982 to John Paul II, quoted in the introduction: “The third part of the secret refers to Our Lady’s words: ‘If not [Russia] will spread her errors throughout the world...’”; “a symbolic revelation, conditioned by whether we accept or not what the Message itself asks of us”; “since we did not heed this appeal of the Message, we see that it has been fulfilled.”
26. CDF, *Message of Fatima*, theological commentary, part “Public Revelation and private revelations—their theological status,” quoting CCC 66–67 and Lambertini (the future Benedict XIV) from his treatise on beatification and canonization, and E. Dhanis as cited above. The criterion he then states: “private revelation... its orientation to Christ himself... when it becomes independent of him or even presents itself as another and better plan of salvation, more important than the Gospel, then it certainly does not come from the Holy Spirit.”
27. CDF, *Message of Fatima*, theological commentary, part “The anthropological structure of private revelations.” This is the category invoked in §2 for the October war statement: translation through the seer’s finite faculties is the Church’s own controlling frame, not an editorial invention.
28. CDF, *Message of Fatima*, theological commentary, part “An attempt to interpret the ‘secret’ of Fatima,” quoting Jn 16:33. Also there: the vision’s images of mountain, city, and cross read as the arena of history; the century of martyrs seen “as in a mirror”; and his personal recollection that Lucia told him the purpose of all the apparitions was “to help people to grow more and more in faith, hope and love—everything else was intended to lead to this.”
29. Second part: CDF, *Message of Fatima* (Third Memoir text). Pontevedra and Tuy: Dicastery for the Causes of Saints, decree on the heroic virtues of Sister Lucia, 22 June 2023 (Portuguese text distributed by the Sanctuary; References). These experiences of the professed religious were never the object of the 1930 Leiria judgment, whose clause reaches only the 1917 Cova da Iria visions; their standing rests on the Holy See’s practical reception, notably in the 2000 dossier and the 2023 decree’s historical summary.
30. Pius XII, radio message to Portugal with the prayer of consecration, 31 October 1942, Italian text at https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/it/speeches/1942/documents/hf_p-xii_spe_19421031_immaculata.html; *Sacro vergente*

anno, 7 July 1952, Italian text at https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/it/apost_letters/documents/hf_p-xii_apl_19520707_sacro-vergente-anno.html (“consacriamo tutti i popoli della Russia al medesimo Cuore immacolato”; editorial translations).

31. CDF, *Message of Fatima*, introduction, quoting the 1981 and 1984 acts (with references to *Insegnamenti*) and Lucia’s letter of 8 November 1989; the Portuguese sentence is printed there. The introduction’s two statements of the 1981 date (7 June as celebrated; “7 May” in a later sentence) contain an internal slip reproduced as found; the Pentecost celebration was 7 June 1981. The 2023 heroic-virtues decree repeats the settled position: on 25 March 1984 Lucia “saw the Consecration accomplished by the Pope in union with all the bishops, the request of Our Lady being fulfilled” (editorial translation).
32. Francis, Act of Consecration to the Immaculate Heart of Mary, 25 March 2022, official English text at <https://www.vatican.va/content/francesco/en/prayers/documents/20220325-atto-consacrazione-cuoredimaria.html>; Letter to the Bishops, 21 March 2022, at <https://www.vatican.va/content/francesco/en/letters/2022/documents/20220321-lettera-consacrazione-cuoredimaria.html> (announcement at the Angelus of 20 March; celebration and timing described in the letter). The letter presents the act as a “gesture of the universal Church”; it does not present itself as supplying a deficiency in 1984. The parallel celebration at Fátima by Cardinal Krajewski as papal envoy was announced by the Holy See and widely reported (checked 2026-07-25 in contemporary Vatican-connected coverage); it is incidental to the act’s object.
33. Lucia to John Paul II, 12 May 1982, in CDF, *Message of Fatima*, introduction: “And let us not say that it is God who is punishing us in this way; on the contrary it is people themselves who are preparing their own punishment. In his kindness God warns us and calls us to the right path, while respecting the freedom he has given us; hence people are responsible.”
34. Paul VI: *Signum magnum*, 13 May 1967, Vatican web text; pilgrimage attested throughout the Sanctuary’s records. Benedict XVI, homily at the Esplanade of the Shrine, 13 May 2010, English text at https://www.vatican.va/content/benedict-xvi/en/homilies/2010/documents/hf_ben-xvi_hom_20100513_fatima.html. Papal visits establish papal devotion and pastoral government; they are not additional judgments on the events.
35. Deaths and 1989 decrees: Sanctuary seer chronology. Beatification: John Paul II, homily at Fátima, 13 May 2000, Vatican web text. Canonization: Francis, homily at the Holy Mass with the rite of canonization of Blesseds Francisco Marto and Jacinta Marto, Shrine of Our Lady of Fátima, 13 May 2017, English text at https://www.vatican.va/content/francesco/en/homilies/2017/documents/papa-francesco_20170513_omelia-pellegrinaggio-fatima.html, quoting *Memoirs* III, 6. The Latin formula of canonization pronounced in the rite is in the celebration booklet, not re-verified here. A canonization certifies the sanctity of the persons; it does not adjudicate the apparitions’ every detail.
36. Dicastery for the Causes of Saints, decree on the heroic virtues of the Servant of God Maria Lucia of Jesus and of the Immaculate Heart, 22 June 2023 (Portuguese text in the Sanctuary’s documentation collection; References); waiver and diocesan phase: Sanctuary seer chronology.
37. Holy See Press Office, “Communiqué on articles regarding the Third Secret of Fatima,” 21 May 2016, English bulletin text at <https://press.vatican.va/content/salastampa/en/bollettino/pubblico/2016/05/21/160521b.html>. The claims answered are identified in the communiqué’s own first paragraph; they are recited here only as the object of the Holy See’s response.
38. DDF, *Norms*, 17 May 2024, English text at https://www.vatican.va/roman_curia/congregations/cfaith/documents/rc_ddf_doc_20240517_norme-fenomeni-soprannaturali_en.html: conclusions at nn. 17–22, the rule at n. 23; approval, effective date, and replacement of the 25 February 1978 norms in the final formula and art. 27.
39. DDF documents index at <https://www.doctrinafidei.va/en/documenti.html>, listing “Documents Regarding The Message of Fatima (26 June 2000)” as the Dicastery’s Fátima entry; search bounds in Appendix A.
40. CDF, *Message of Fatima*, theological commentary, whose text supplies both quotations (the completeness formulation, and CCC 67 as quoted there); Lambertini and Dhanis as in §5. The 2024 norms restate the same boundary for the current discipline: even a *Nihil obstat* authorizes only prudent adherence and never certifies supernatural origin (nn. 17, 23; art. 22 §2).
41. For the reported-message discipline observed throughout this study: a sentence is the Lady’s only in the sense that a named witness reported it at a stated date; the phrase “reported message” is the study’s default register, and the strata (1917 records; 1924 sworn interrogation; 1935–1941 memoirs; 1944 manuscript) are identified at each use.
42. Center as stated by the 2000 commentary (“the exhortation to prayer as the path of ‘salvation for souls’ and, likewise, the summons to penance and conversion”; Lucia to Ratzinger: the purpose of the apparitions was growth in faith, hope, and love, “everything else was intended to lead to this”); Rosary requests in the 1917 records (*Seleção*, Docs. 1, 3, 14); sacrifice-for-sinners wording from the memoir stratum as printed by the Sanctuary’s narrative page.

A Scope, Status, and Qualifications

Question and thesis boundary

This study answers one question: what occurred and was reported at Fátima in 1917 on the contemporaneous record; what the competent ecclesiastical authorities have judged, in exactly which acts, words, and objects; how the documentary corpus—above all the memoirs and the three-part secret—actually developed; and what those judgments oblige and leave open. It is a source-audited study instrument, ecclesial-judgment-first in method: not a devotional narrative, a critical edition, a magisterial act, a scientific investigation of the solar phenomenon, or a complete history of Fátima devotion. It proposes no judgment of its own on supernaturality.

Corpus and exclusions

Included: the six 1917 apparitions and the 13 October solar phenomenon in the 1917–1930 documentary record as critically edited in the Sanctuary’s *Seleção de documentos*; the diocesan process (1922 provision, 1924 interrogation, 1930 commission report) and the 13 October 1930 pastoral letter; Lucia’s memoirs and the secret’s composition, custody, and publication through the CDF’s *Message of Fatima* (26 June 2000), read in full; the consecration acts of 1942, 1952, 1981/1982/1984, and 2022 with the 1989 letter; the 2016 press-office communiqué; the seers’ causes and the 2017 canonizations; and the 2024 DDF norms as they bear on current standing. Excluded or bounded: any certification of a physical mechanism or adjudication of individual solar-phenomenon testimony; the 1915 reports, 1916 angel cycle, 1921 experience, and Pontevedra/Tuy events except as reported and received (never placed inside the 1930 clause); complete reproduction of the memoirs or of any modern translation; “fourth secret,” date-setting, and automatic-salvation theories beyond the controlling public answers (§§4, 7); every papal Fátima reference, political appropriation, and polemical controversy; and any declaration about the present “conversion of Russia.”

Geography, chronology, and currentness

Subject geography: the parish of Fátima (Cova da Iria, Aljustrel, Valinhos), the diocese of Leiria (Leiria-Fátima), Porto, Pontevedra and Tuy (Spain), Rome. Subject range: 1917 to the DDF norms of 2024 and the causes’ state in 2023. As-of date: all mutable claims—current controlling status, the DDF documents index, sanctuary pages—were checked on 2026-07-25; no later act superseding the 1930 judgment or the 2000 interpretation was located. Stable historical facts are not given artificial currentness. Negative results are bounded searches (recorded in the Notes and the tracked research records), correctable by better evidence, never guarantees.

Taxonomy and terminology

Kept distinct throughout: *contemporaneous record* (1917 interrogations, press, letters); *sworn process testimony* (1924); *retrospective memoir* (1935–1941, 1944); *competent judgment* (the 1930 diocesan act); *papal act of piety* (consecrations, entrustments); *authoritative interpretation* (the 2000 commentary); *reception* (feasts, pilgrimages, canonizations, shrine development), which establishes only its own form of approval; and *editorial synthesis*. “Reported message” is the default register for all words attributed to the apparition. “Worthy of belief” (*digna de crédito*) is the 1930 act’s own formula and is not translated into the 2024 taxonomy. *Fides humana* names the prudent human assent invited by approved private revelation.

Source hierarchy and method

Priority: the exact operative and documentary texts in identified witnesses (the Sanctuary’s critical selection for 1917–1930; the Holy See’s own web texts for 2000–2024); then competent summaries in Holy See acts (the 2023 heroic-virtues decree); then the Sanctuary’s institutional pages for scaffolding; then scholarship, used here only through the controlling documents. Quotations are exact from the named witness; Portuguese and Italian sources are quoted in the original where wording is operative, with editorial translations visibly editorial. No project or AI rendering is offered as a received translation, and no prayer text is printed for recitation in this study.

Qualifications and unresolved items

(1) The 1930 act is quoted from the Sanctuary’s 2013 critical selection; the 1930 imprint and the diocesan original were not consulted. (2) The fifteen-volume *Documentação Crítica* was used only through the one-volume selection; unselected documents were not searched. (3) The 1942 first publications of the secret’s first two parts were not verified in their original imprints; the dating rests on standard accounts and the 2000 edition’s “already... published.” (4) *O Século* was read in the critical transcription, not in newspaper facsimile. (5) The August 1917 apparition’s day (19 August) rests on the memoir stratum. (6) Lucia’s memoirs were used through the 2000 dossier, the 2023 decree, and the Sanctuary’s excerpts, not read integrally in a critical edition. (7) The English of the Vatican pages quoted is the Holy See’s own; its translators are unnamed, and the 2000 introduction contains an internal 7 May/7 June 1981 slip reproduced as found. (8) Archival claims underlying the 1980s consecration controversy were not examined; the study reports the position of record. (9) No independent Mariological, historical, canonical, Portuguese-philological, medical, or scientific review has occurred; no ecclesiastical review or approval is claimed or implied.

Rights

Project prose is original and intended for CC BY 4.0. Quotations remain under their own status: the underlying 1917–1930 Portuguese documents (newspaper reports of the deceased-in-1932 Avelino de Almeida, official diocesan acts, interrogations) are public domain, but the Sanctuary’s 2013 critical transcription and apparatus are © Santuário de Fátima and are quoted briefly with citation; Holy See web texts (the 2000 dossier, homilies, the 2024 norms, the 2022 act) are quoted within ordinary scholarly limits with citation; the Sanctuary’s English memoir excerpts likewise. Online availability is not treated as a reuse license; no complete document is reproduced.

B References

Witnesses are listed with role and rights notes; access date for all web loci is 2026-07-25 unless stated. Stable source identities for the starred entries are registered in the repository source library; this publication’s bindings are in `research/source-bindings.toml`.

Primary documentary corpus, 1917–1930

- **Documentação Crítica de Fátima: Seleção de documentos (1917–1930)* (Fátima: Santuário de Fátima, 2013; ISBN 978-972-8213-91-6; © Santuário de Fátima; scientific sponsorship of the Centro de Estudos de História Religiosa, Universidade Católica Portuguesa), distributed without charge by the Sanctuary as a 653-page PDF: https://www.fatima.pt/files/upload/fontes/F001_DCF_selecao.pdf (documentation page <https://www.fatima.pt/en/documentacao/f001-documentacao-critica-de-fatima-selecao-de-documentos-1917-1930>). Role: critical witness for the 1917 interrogations (Docs. 1, 3, 14, 18), the press dossier (Docs. 4, 13, 21), the process acts (Docs. 68, 120), and the 1930 pastoral letter (Doc. 133) with its promulgation account (Doc. 134). The underlying 1917–1930 documents are public domain; the edition’s transcription and apparatus remain the Sanctuary’s, quoted briefly with citation.
- **José Alves Correia da Silva*, Bishop of Leiria, *Carta Pastoral sobre o culto de Nossa Senhora de Fátima*, 13 October 1930, as printed in the above selection, Doc. 133 (published earlier as DCF II, Doc. 11). Role: the operative approval act, quoted exactly in §1. Ceilings recorded in §3.3.

Holy See acts and documents

- **Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith*, *The Message of Fatima* (26 June 2000), English text, read in full: https://www.vatican.va/roman_curia/congregations/cfaith/documents/rc_con_cfaith_doc_20000626_message-fatima_en.html. Role: controlling dossier and interpretation—Bertone introduction (custody history, 1984 act, 1989 letter), the secret’s three parts in translation with facsimiles, John Paul II’s letter of 19 April 2000, the 27 April 2000 conversation record (the 1960-date answer), the Sodano announcement of 13 May 2000, and Cardinal Ratzinger’s theological commentary, quoted at its exact wording.

- *Holy See Press Office, “Communiqué on articles regarding the Third Secret of Fatima,” 21 May 2016: <https://press.vatican.va/content/salastampa/en/bollettino/pubblico/2016/05/21/160521b.html>. Role: Benedict XVI’s denial of the Dollinger claims; completeness of the 2000 publication.
- *Dicastery for the Doctrine of the Faith, *Norms for Proceeding in the Discernment of Alleged Supernatural Phenomena* (given 17 May 2024; approved 4 May 2024; effective 19 May 2024): https://www.vatican.va/roman_curia/congregations/cfaith/documents/rc_ddd_doc_20240517_norme-fenomeni-soprannaturali_en.html. Role: current procedural law; six conclusions; n. 23 rule; its presentation’s citation of the Fátima 2000 explanation of approval. Checked negative: the DDF documents index (<https://www.doctrinafidei.va/en/documenti.html>) lists no Fátima act after 2000.
- *Francis, Homily, Holy Mass with the rite of canonization of Blesseds Francisco Marto and Jacinta Marto, Shrine of Our Lady of Fátima, 13 May 2017: https://www.vatican.va/content/francesco/en/homilies/2017/documents/papa-francesco_20170513_omelia-pellegrinaggio-fatima.html. Role: canonization record and its homiletic framing.
- *Francis, *Act of Consecration to the Immaculate Heart of Mary*, 25 March 2022: <https://www.vatican.va/content/francesco/en/prayers/documents/20220325-atto-consacrazione-cuoredimaria.html>; with the Letter to the Bishops, 21 March 2022: <https://www.vatican.va/content/francesco/en/letters/2022/documents/20220321-lettera-consacrazione-cuoredimaria.html>. Role: the 2022 act’s text (Russia and Ukraine named) and its self-description.
- Pius XII, Radio message to Portugal with the prayer of consecration to the Immaculate Heart, 31 October 1942 (Italian): https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/it/speeches/1942/documents/hf_p-xii_spe_19421031_immaculata.html; *Sacro vergente anno*, 7 July 1952 (Italian): https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/it/apost_letters/documents/hf_p-xii_apl_19520707_sacro-vergente-anno.html. Role: the 1942 and 1952 consecration texts.
- John Paul II, Homily at the beatification of Francisco and Jacinta, Fátima, 13 May 2000: https://www.vatican.va/content/john-paul-ii/en/homilies/2000/documents/hf_jp-ii_hom_20000513_beatification-fatima.html. Role: beatification record (identity confirmed; not quoted).
- Benedict XVI, Homily at the Esplanade of the Shrine, Fátima, 13 May 2010: https://www.vatican.va/content/benedict-xvi/en/homilies/2010/documents/hf_ben-xvi_hom_20100513_fatima.html. Role: the “prophetic mission” sentence, quoted exactly.
- Paul VI, *Signum magnum*, 13 May 1967, Vatican web text (cited for date and fact of the anniversary act; not quoted).
- Dicastery for the Causes of Saints, Decree on the heroic virtues of the Servant of God Maria Lucia of Jesus and of the Immaculate Heart, 22 June 2023, Portuguese text distributed by the Sanctuary: https://www.fatima.pt/files/upload/documentos_do_magisterio/20023-06-22decretosobreasvirtudesheroicasdairmaluciadejesusedoimaculadocoracao.pdf. Role: competent summary of Lucia’s life, Pontevedra and Tuy, the memoirs’ dating, and the 1984 fulfillment sentence.

Sanctuary of Fátima institutional pages

- “Narrative of the Apparitions” (<https://www.fatima.pt/en/pages/narrative-of-the-apparitions->) and “Chronology of the Three Seers” (<https://www.fatima.pt/en/pages/chronology-of-the-three-seers>). Role: factual scaffolding (memoir dates, seer biography, Valinhos account with its source note) and the Sanctuary’s English memoir excerpts, quoted briefly. Ceiling: institutional presentation, cited as the Sanctuary’s own account, not as critical edition.

Not consulted at first hand (recorded ceilings)

The 1930 União Gráfica imprint; the Leiria diocesan archive; the fifteen-volume *Documentação Crítica* beyond the selection; *O Século* and *Ilustração Portuguesa* in facsimile; the 1942 first imprints of the secret’s first two parts; Lucia’s memoirs in integral critical edition; *Insegnamenti* volumes cited by the 2000 dossier; the celebration booklet with the 2017 canonization formula; archival materials alleged in the consecration controversy.

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